

Horses

The earliest horses were small, leaf-eating mammals that lived in forests. Around 20 million years ago, Earth's climate changed and grasslands began to replace forests. Horses moved to the open plains and adapted to a diet of grass. They grew larger and their legs became longer, making them swifter on their feet. Hundreds of different prehistoric horse species have been found all over the world. They show that the evolution of the horse was like a tree, with many dead ends.

Hipparion

hip-AH-ree-on



- **When** 23–2 million years ago (Neogene)
- **Fossil location** N. America, Europe, Asia, Africa
- **Habitat** Grasslands, plains
- **Length** 5 ft (2 m)
- **Diet** Leaves and grass

With its long muzzle and slender legs, the lightly built *Hipparion* resembled a modern pony. Unlike horses today, which have only one toe on each foot, it had three. Its full weight was borne on its large middle toe, which ended in a hoof. The other toes did not touch the ground, so the feet sprung off the ground quickly, helping the animal to run faster.



▲ GRASS-EATER *Hipparion* lived on grassy plains. Horses never fully evolved the ability to digest grass. As a result, their manure is full of undigested stalks.



FAMILY FACT FILE

Key features

- Long, narrow heads
- Long necks
- Slender legs
- Large teeth
- Hoofed feet, with odd numbers of toes (some had one toe, others three)

When

Horses first appeared in the Paleogene Period, 54 million years ago.